control of the administration. Ershad also planned to convene a presidential election in November 1986. In his meetings with CIA officials, Ershad had claimed that martial law in Bangladesh couldn't be completely lifted until his position as president had been secured either through popular elections or a martial law decree. The Indian government was perturbed by the development and when Ershad visited Delhi again, President Zail Singh reminded him about India's sacrifice in carving out Bangladesh. According to documents from the MEA, Singh told Ershad that there are perhaps few countries in the world with as much in common as India and Bangladesh. 'Not only have we shed our blood together in the cause of liberation and national independence, but we are bound together by common strands of history and culture,' President Singh told Ershad.

The Bangladeshi dictator turned leader, however, was unmoved. His focus was unresolved issues between the two countries rather than warmth. 'We are often asked, at home and abroad, about our unresolved issues with India. People have wondered how we can achieve a meaningful and enduring relationship when some important issues are still outstanding.' The MEA documents stated:

The pivotal question in any bilateral relationship is, of course, how best such problems or differences can be tackled and resolved. Does the answer lie in confrontation, acrimony or pressure? Or will it not be far more effectual to ap-

proach them in a spirit of amity and accommodation? Surely, there cannot be any two opinions about the second option.

Ershad's comments rattled the Indian government officials. The external spy agency was shocked. Their response in various